

**Understanding the educational aspirations of two preschool  
Chinese migrant parents in one ECE centre**

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## **ABSTRACT**

Most Chinese migrants' families are reported to have settled in Auckland, with children enrolled in local early childhood centers (Kan et al., 2020). To add to the mainstream literature, this paper emphasized both overall and educational aspirations of two Chinese migrant parents living in Tauranga, a provisional city outside of Auckland. It illustrated their beliefs and involvement experiences using findings from a qualitative study. Also, semi-structured individual interviews were done to explore the reasons for the unique expectations and barriers of engagement in their children's learning in the centre. Based on thematic analysis, it provided potential implications for Tauranga-based preschool Chinese migrant parents

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## **One Introduction**

This small-scale qualitative research project recorded the individual educational aspirations and opinions on home-center involvement of two Chinese immigrant parents of preschoolers in Tauranga. The research, relying on empirical data gathered from semi-structured interviews with two participants, looked at their educational aspirations, the level of current home-centre interaction, and provided the implications for the future. Importantly, a qualitative method supplemented descriptive data and revealed significant fluid cross-city aspirations, a language barrier, unrecognized cultural communicative functions, improper knowledge from unofficial sources of information, and possibly contrasting instructional viewpoints. Also, according to the research results, home-school communication approaches such as parent meetings with bilingual translation services and written feedbacks are expected to be adopted to facilitate effective interaction and assimilation of Chinese immigrant parents of preschoolers in Tauranga.

## **Two Literature review**

### **2.1 Introduction**

With New Zealand being increasingly diverse (Spoonley, 2015), there is a rising drive to incorporate multicultural views on early childhood education (ECE) (Mellor & Corrigan 2004; Richards et al., 2007; Portera 2008). Literature supporting these views highlights the importance of parental participation in ECE in western countries including New Zealand (Grey & Horgan, 2003; Hartzell & Zlotoff, 2004; Blanc et al, 2004; Billman et al, 2005; Knopf & Swick, 2007; Ward, 2009). However, the fact is that Chinese migrant parents' involvement in New Zealand ECE programs is limited, and their educational ambitions differ from the mainstream norm of New Zealand (Guo, 2006; Wu, 2009; Zhang, 2012; Chan, 2018).

The theme of this literature is to understand the educational aspirations of two preschool Chinese migrant parents in one ECE in New Zealand. It's critical to place a high priority on the ECE context in which Chinese migrant children find themselves, as well as the relevant benefits, challenges, and potential strategies. Drawing on the advantages of the narrative review and a qualitative methodology, this literature review analyzes educational aspirations of two preschool Chinese migrant parents in one ECE centre in New Zealand, the hurdles that impede their involvement, and possible home-school communication implications.

### **2.2 The educational aspirations of Chinese immigrant parents**

According to Fan and Chen's (2001) 's study, parental hopes are the most key factor affecting children's' performance. Asian parents including Chinese immigrant parents have a strong tradition of appreciating

learning efforts, with the Confucian ideology impacting their faith (Ji & Koblinsky, 2009; Y. M. Kim & Greene, 2003; Li, Du, et al., 2011; Li, He, et al., 2011; Olsen & Fuller, 2008; N. Pang, 2011; V. O. Pang, et al., 2004; Qin, et al., 2011). To begin with, they hope that sociological outcomes like improved confidence, as well as interpersonal skills, will be embedded in children's learning. Because they genuinely think that pleasure, esteem, and the ability to adapt and compete in host society characterize a great life (Guo, 2014). Second, prior research has reflected that most Chinese immigrant parents have great standards for their children's academic mastery and would provide home learning. Chinese migrant parents, for example, can build a strong foundation in mathematics to their children by fostering a positive attitude and mathematics instruction at home, thereby contributing to learning effectiveness (Huntsinger et al., 1997; Pan et al., 2006). Third, Chan's research confirms that Chinese migrant parents use their cross-border understanding to form hybrid strategies to settle cultural issues, as well as to advance their children's language and culture assets (Chan, 2018).

### **2.3 Benefits of home-centre partnership**

Many studies have found that home-parent collaboration is a significant element for migrant children's academic performance, sense of belonging, and overall well-being. Some research suggests parents' effective home-family partnership influence children's academic growth in a positive way (Fan & Chen, 2001; Hidalgo et al., 2004; Joshi, et al., 2005; Vazquez-Nuttall et al., 2006). This is also proved true for migrant children (Jeynes, 2007), Chinese migrant children included. To be specific, an effective parental partnership is found to improve children's educational success, including positive social skills, positive attitudes towards school and higher student achievement, thus improving wellbeing (Sheridan et al., 2010). Fortunately, several researchers discovered that these educational benefits correspond to the top objectives of Chinese migrant parents, which emphasizes learning, skill development, and a passion for learning (Li & Wang, 2004). Other research indicates that the benefits of home-parent teamwork continue beyond the early years and into the school years (Cairney, 2003). This is consistent with Guo's (2014) findings claiming that Chinese families want their children to have a long educational success and work hard to attain it. Given these current benefits and the future potentials for Chinese migrant children, it is critical to develop a home-centre link with Chinese parents.

### **2.4 Barriers that hinder Chinese parental partnership**

#### **2.4.1 Power imbalance in New Zealand ECE services**

Literature has been accumulating on power imbalance in New Zealand ECE services. They discover that when ECE services in New Zealand were managed under dominant parental engagement standards, ethnic

minorities, including Chinese migrant families, were in danger of exclusion (Reay, 1995; Crozier, 1997; Todd & Higgins, 1998; Lareau & Horvat, 1999; Lareau, 2003; Griffith & Smith, 2005). Recently, research shows that teachers often consider immigrant parenting to be inadequate when measured against that of the mainstream. Also, certain social attitudes jointly define immigrant parents as inadequate in terms of child-rearing (Reiff et al., 2000). Unfortunately, few investigations concentrate on Chinese individuals, with many focusing on a broad ethnicity labelled “Asian” (Huang, 1993; Lee, 1995; Ebbeck & Glover, 1998; Lee & Manning, 2001), thus perpetuating stereotypes and overlooking individual differences. One exception is Wu’s doctoral study identifying unbalanced power relations between New Zealand ECE teachers and Chinese migrant parents (Wu, 2009). she observes that when confronted with a disadvantageous educational situation, Chinese migrant parents tend to deal with their goals on their own rather than seeking the assistance of instructors (Wu, 2009). Above all, with the power imbalance evident in New Zealand’s ECE services, more study focusing on Chinese immigrants is essential.

#### **2.4.2 The differences in the understanding of play and learning**

Many studies demonstrate that the benefits of play have been widely spread in New Zealand ECE (Santer et al., 2007; Claiborne & Drewery, 2010). For example, *Te Whāriki* strongly values play-based learning in ECE (White et al., 2009). Supporting research claims for the potential of free play to develop spatial awareness and cognitive abilities (Ortega, 2003; Gregory et al., 2003; White et al., 2009). Recent studies have highlighted play as a unique emotional need and relaxation in the ECE context (Parmar et al., 2004; Santer et al., 2007; Naftali, 2010; Claiborne & Drewery, 2010). However, according to Huang (2013), Chinese migrant parents still do not generally embrace play-based learning. They think that academic accomplishment outweighs play in growth (Roopnarine & Johnson, 2001; Chang, 2003). Biggs attributes this preference to the influence of Chinese Culture of Confucian roots (Biggs, 2005). Recently, Wu (2009) broadens attribution to a hybrid of cultural influences, including Confucianism, positivistic beliefs, and western concepts. Wu’s doctoral research concentrates on Chinese participants’ input and employs the structural ecology approach, which makes his findings trustworthy.

#### **2.4.3 Other barriers**

Initially, some research identifies that the main obstacles for the parental involvement of Asian immigrant families lie in a lack of awareness of the education system, low self-confidence (Bermudez & Marquez, 1996) and a relatively low degree of education (Ji & Koblinsky, 2009). Zhang (2016), in recent doctorate research, gives a more thorough view. Zhang discovers that linguistic and cultural differences make it challenging for Chinese immigrant parents to involve themselves in ECE, based on research of 120

Chinese migrant families and 127 non-Chinese families. Also, Given New Zealand's current immigration policies, more high-skilled Chinese immigrants have altered the makeup of Chinese migrant parents (Department of Labour, New Zealand, 2009), with many coming from good educational backgrounds and having high and dynamic ambitions for their children (Zhang, 2014).

## **2.5 Implications**

According to the literature, a strong personal relationship is a crucial part of parent-centre partnerships. (Adams & Christenson, 2000; Anderson & Minke, 2007; Laforett & Mendez, 2010). Also, many sociocultural studies urge for an instructor's critical evaluation of any biases, preconceptions, and inadequate views of households. (Christenson et al., 2009; Giovacco-Johnson, 2009; Kersey & Masterson, 2009; Schumacher, 2000; Powell & McCauley, 2011). A following up research (Chan & Ritchie, 2016) gives significant specific strategies (Bhabha, 1994) and funds of knowledge (González, 2005). They suggest ongoing interactions with Chinese families as well as clear invites to their children's learning (Lai & Ishiyama, 2004; Chan & Ritchie, 2016). The assessment shows that all the implications are designed to fulfil the theories and goals of mainstream development needs, with few focusing on unique expectations and objectives of Chinese participants. One exception is Zhang (2014)'s research targeting Chinese migrant parents. With "a sense of possibilities" being the most significant obstacle to Chinese immigrant parents' involvement, Zhang strongly advises that instructors personalize their invitation to the expectations of Chinese immigrants (Zhang et al., 2014). They will be able to identify possibilities for engagement more successfully if they are presented with potentials that are useful and appropriate to them.

## **2.6 Conclusion**

This literature review identifies the significance and benefits of parental involvement of Chinese migrant parents. Faced with inequity caused by super-diversity, New Zealand national policies show a strong intention and efforts to strengthen parental engagement. Chinese children may reap the rewards of a successful home-parent collaboration in terms of academic performance, a sense of belonging, and well-being, which substantially match the objectives of Chinese migrant parents. Also, it identifies major barriers that negatively impact Chinese parental partnership in New Zealand ECE services, including power imbalance, the differences in the opinions of play and learning, and the disparities of languages and culture. This is then followed by potential implications for New Zealand ECE sectors. Effective personal relationships, continual conversations and explicit and Chinese-style invitations to their children's learning are identified by research as useful to promote critical and responsive pedagogy.



The gap identified is that most related research does not concentrate solely on the distinctiveness of Chinese migrant parents, thus the effectiveness of the findings is not convincing. Also, few studies examined age or geographical variances. While Auckland has the biggest number of Asian immigrants, Chinese immigrants in other places with different facilities and social links may have diverse educational needs.

### **Three Methodology and data analysis**

#### **3.1 Methodology**

Due to the lack of research describing the aspirations of Chinese immigrant parents of preschoolers in the New Zealand ECE context outside Auckland, the study utilized a qualitative process of phenomenology. People are core to qualitative studies (O'Leary, 2010), and the core was on unpacking the meanings of their educational beliefs and experiences (Liamputtong & Ezzy, 2005; Schram, 2006).

#### **3.2 Research method**

##### **3.2.1 Case study**

I utilized a qualitative case study in one ECE organization. Because a case study technique is appropriate for conducting an in-depth and thorough analysis of a complicated and unique topic in the actual world (Stake, 1995). Also, it is a technique of empirical research of events that occur, particularly when the limits between the phenomena and the backdrop are blurred (Yin, 2011).

##### **3.2.2 Interviews**

Because language is a vital means of communication for comprehension and evaluation through conversations, semi-structured interviews were adopted as the main approach of data collection in this project (Schram, 2006). I used them to comprehend participants' educational aspirations and needs for this small-scale qualitative study. The interviews gave interviewers the opportunity to explain and expand on questions (Carter, 2018). This method ensured that both the participants and I understood the interview's content and encouraged more thoughtful responses. According to Cohen et al. (2011), I was careful not to sway the results of the interview based on my own preferences via verbal or nonverbal cues. In addition, open-ended questions were used to promote insights and thoughts (Kvale, 2007). The questions were direct, leading the interviewees to topics without enacting detailed views (Kvale, 2007).

##### **3.2.3 The setting and the participants**

I was doing a practicum in a Montessori ECE centre, located in Tauranga, a provisional city in the Bay of Plenty. Also, I was working with 8 staff members and children of various ethnicities, including 7 Māori children, 42 Pākehā children, and 2 Chinese migrant children.

All interviewees were recruited at the centre where I was undertaking my practicum. Among the standards of recruitment, choosing convenient attendees is advised (Mutch, 2013), for the advantages of productivity and reduced savings (Miles et al., 2014). The parents of the two children in the centre were my target participants. Both participants were female and aged 35 years old and 39 years old with bachelor's degrees in China. They were rooted in China, and they had been living in New Zealand for more than 8 years at the time of the interviews. They both had one boy in the centre. They preferred to use Mandarin in the interview.

### **3.3 Data collection and analysis techniques and outcomes**

#### **3.3.1 Data collection techniques and outcomes**

To collect data, I used semi-structured interviews and an interpretive method. Two major positive outcomes of semi-structured interviews were observed. First, participants elaborated on relevant threads, eventually arriving at concrete conclusions (Song, 2020). Also, during the conversations, new paths and the expansion of study questions (Cohen et al., 2000) were explored. When interpreting various components of the research, such as stories, observations from people's experiences, and opinions, empirical interpretivism was used, so that knowledge and beliefs were obtained from within rather than from without (Mack, 2010).

#### **3.3.2 Data analysis techniques and outcomes**

I transcribed the data stored on my own computer as the initial stage in data analysis. For the sake of accuracy, I ensured that the data is captured in the original language. Following that, I reflected on and commented on my "audit trail" (Punch, 2005, p. 200) to achieve compliance and stability in the processes of data collection, processing, and reporting (Carter, 2018). Participants double-checked the interpreted data for any potential misunderstanding (Carter, 2018).

Also, thematic analysis was utilized in data analysis. The thematic analysis focused on recognizable concepts that arise through data analysis and gave preliminary interpretations for the results (Lodico et al., 2006). Also, it was employed where the recurrence was considered to reflect major trends (O'Leary, 2010). This method was appropriate for processing and interpreting individual empirical data collected, and it allowed easy structure for analysis (Lodico, et al., 2006).

Furthermore, an inductive reasoning technique was chosen primarily to reflect the voice of participants in this study. During data analysis, the structure and the coding largely depended on the survey's objectives, comments, and replies from individuals (Creswell, 2002). An inductive reasoning method did

not adhere to any pre-set coding scheme (Lodico, et al., 2006). Instead, it allowed subjects' perspectives rather than the researchers to guide the study (Creswell, 2002).

#### **Four Ethical considerations**

The ethical considerations complied with Toi Ohomai's *Human Ethics Code for Research, Evaluation and Teaching* (Toi Ohomai, 2018) and Carter (2018)'s study. When dealing with project participants, obtaining feedback, assessing data, and reporting conclusions, my general philosophy was to be truthful, accurate, and fair. Although this research only focused on Chinese migrant parents, I applied the principles of respect and protection to Māori whānau. Although there will be no Children participants in this research, in case any of the children's voices, interviews were in collaboration with loving, experienced adults who gave adequate support and direction. To protect children's privacy and safety, any identifiable information about them was removed and filtered. I used pseudonyms for all the participants and children (Carter, 2018). The relevant details were reviewed and approved by their parents. Also, children's voices were heard and valued through their works and participants' feedbacks throughout the initiative.

Before completing the consent forms, both participants were provided with basic information about the project, such as its goal, content, potential outcomes, and participants' rights, via written forms. As Mutch (2013) addresses, attendees in the investigation should be sufficiently briefed about the reasons, performance, and potential diffusion of the study before agreeing to participate. In addition, participant information sheets, informed consent, and consent forms, including those for relevant photographs and videos, were translated (as in Appendices) and distributed to participants in person.

Furthermore, each participant had the choice not to participate in this study and to refuse to respond to the queries. They were free to ask any inquiries regarding the project throughout their participation. They were free to reach the author or the supervisor in case of any issues and may also drop out at any anytime whatever the reason. The data were stored on my password-protected personal computer. After the required storage time (at least 3 years), the information will be deleted by me.

Drawing on Kaupapa Māori theory, three concepts of “mana, maramatanga, and mahimahi” were considered when conducting this project (Paki, 2007). I used the idea of “mana” to validate the value and power of participants (Marsden, 2003), which fueled the desire for communal and many advantages. Also, I employed the concept “maramatanga”, which claimed that knowledge had the potential to enable and improve people. This was combined with the idea of "mahitahi" (to work together). I worked collaboratively as a whānau member of our project group, rather than acting as independent actors or neutral observers (Powick, 2002). Sharing the same Chinese cultural origins with the two Chinese migrant

parents, I was able to conduct this study in terms of consultation and consent following Kaupapa Māori theory. This also contributed to eliminating bias or power issues in the research.

Because the research relied on narrative documentation, I double-checked all the material gathered to ensure there was no sensitive messages for ethical reasons and returned the transcribed results to participants for more accurate feedback. All information was saved on my personal password-protected computer. The final report will be printed out and distributed to the centre manager, Toi Ohomai, participants, and my supervisor and presented in class at the end of my course.

## **Five Research findings and discussion**

### **5.1 Research findings**

#### **5.1.1 The priorities of educational aspirations**

Regarding the question “What are your top educational aspirations for your child?”, the findings focused on personality and physical building, academic skills and social skills, which were taken as essential for a future better life. First, on the top of their lists was personality and physical building. They showed evident awareness of their children’s own features and highlighted their physical and mental health, which linked to the Chinese teaching philosophy of “Yin Cai Shi Jiao” (teaching based on abilities), and holistic growth (Lin, 2007).

S: “...*I would like my son to take part in more sport activities like Rugby outdoor. That would be beneficial to his body, mind and a spirit of competition...*”

Y: “...*My child is a little shy by nature. I hope him to be more confident and open, so that he can have better relationship with others and be happy...*”

Second, they highly valued academic skills, including literacy and numeracy. Moving to Tauranga from Auckland, they realized the evident differences in educational resources and atmosphere of the two cities and tried to perform home education after school to make up for the disparities.

Interviews also revealed that they were obtaining information using unofficial sources and channels of information, such as friends’ oral stories and relative media.

S: “*I got some information from the websites and other media that enrollment standards of private primary schools in Auckland are much higher than those in Tauranga. In order to get prepared, I hope him to learn more about English writing, counting, nature and science.*”  
“... *the child of my friend is learning counting within 1-50 at 4 years old in Auckland...*”

Y: “*I ever shared information with S about what good primary schools requires for enrollment.*” ... “*I hope him to develop the abilities of thinking and focusing, which is necessary to his following learning in transition period to primary schools.*”

Third, interviews also revealed that the two participants had a firm desire for their children to develop proper social manners and achieve success in New Zealand society.

S: *"...I hope him to unpack proper social interaction codes including table manners and polite words/behaviors in social connections..."*  
*"...I wish that he may have decent jobs like lawyers and doctors in the future..."*

Y: *"...Because of his shyness, I hope him to develop social skills to adapt to the new environment..."*

### 5.1.2 Expectations for regular and culturally responsive ways of involvement

According to the findings, they expressed strong aspirations for more frequent parent-involvement activities, such as the Christmas party held last year. Surprisingly, the two parents defined various bonuses for the same Christmas party, which suited their children's individual needs.

S: *"...He enjoys playing in big activities in the public. active in social*

Y: *"...He (S's child) is shy but good at handcrafts...."*

S: *"...the party helps him to develop a sense of involvement..." "What a pity chances like that are limited..."*

Y: *"...in the party, children made handcrafts and shared with peers...he made more friends" "But it was last year, how I wish the centre had more activities like this..."*

The findings also revealed that participants advocated for culturally responsive communication channels, such as one-on-one parent meetings or individual weekly written reports to parents. They believed that these would provide an effective and more direct channel for parents to engage with centre learning and share home learning with teachers.

Furthermore, the findings revealed that the parents made clear comparisons between Auckland and Tauranga in terms of learning materials and resources. They both expressed a desire to return to Auckland for additional resources such as museums, galleries, and libraries. This point was discovered during this project for the first time. It can be illustrated by Zhang's doctoral research in the literature review, which states that more high-skilled Chinese immigrants with a good educational background may have dynamic ambitions for their children (Zhang, 2014).

### 5.1.3 Barriers of parents' engagement

#### 5.1.3.1 Lack of communication ability in English and the multicultural context

Even the two parents living in New Zealand for up to 8 years stressed the difficulties of using English. It appeared that speaking English had a long-term impact on parental engagement and the residing length in New Zealand does not always minimize this component. So, parents were hesitant to interact with teachers. This is consistent with Zhang 's findings (2014) in the literature review, which state that linguistic and cultural differences add to the difficulties for Chinese immigrant parents to engage with ECE. For example, S: "...English not so good, so I can't understand... Especially when ... talked fast, I couldn't follow at all." Y: "I need the help of my husband if we really need to give some feedback to teachers... my English doesn't work."

#### 5.1.3.2 The limited understanding of play-based learning and home-centre partnership

Findings also showed that they understood the benefits of play but lack awareness of the harm of early training. Also, in conversation about engagement with the centre, they expressed reluctance for fear of bothering teachers. Instead, they would return to online resources and Chinese friends' recommended courses as home learning resources.

|                             | S                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Y                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| play VS structured learning | <i>"...I know play is an important part in children's everyday life... but I see him playing all day long...Hopefully, teachers can arrange more structured learning activities, such as reading, writing, counting in the centre... it will be wonderful if teachers can give them some homework. So that I can cooperate with his learning after school. He has too much free time at home, and he wastes it in watching TV..."</i> | <i>"...I see my son playing at the centre a lot. ...I support that ...Because he sometimes cannot understand the teachers' instruction in English, so, I arrange more home-learning time to develop his English reading ability. ... I use the reading textbook called ... recommended by my Chinese friends. I hope he has more chance to develop this ability..."</i> |
| participation in the centre | <i>"...I think teachers have so many children to take care of, ...I am afraid of bothering them if I go to interrupt her and bring up my expectations..."</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <i>"...From our culture, I always don't like adding troubles to other people, especially the teachers of my son...."</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

## **5.2 Discussion**

### **5.2.1 Aspirations for learning**

In terms of educational aspirations priorities, the findings on personality and physical development, academic skills, and social skills link to previous research in the literature review. During the preschool years, both participants are pursuing "a good life," which is defined by pleasure, esteem, competitive nature, and responsiveness (Guo, 2014). Also, the parents were decisive in their belief that academic achievement was an important factor in leading to "a good life" (Li, 2001; Ochocka & Janzen, 2008). Furthermore, they listed social abilities such as raising their children's awareness of New Zealand's culture, which was a reflection of Chinese parents' strong willingness to adapt to New Zealand.

The new discovery made in this project fills a gap in the literature. The two Chinese immigrant parents of preschoolers in Tauranga, who were on an unstable career path, clearly expected their children to be able to catch up with the learning standard of Auckland. As a result of this aspiration, new, fluid, and hybridised parenting practise emerge (Sanagavarapu, 2010). Also, according to Li's (2007) findings, turning aspirations into practices is dependent on an individuals' attitudes and behaviours, as well as their personal circumstances and the ground. This could explain why home learning is so popular between the two Chinese migrant families. Again, given the deep cultural influence of Confucius philosophy that learning and hard work in ECE lead to a better life (Guo, 2014), cross-city parenting practices in Tauranga are understandable and reasonable, and thus have pedagogical implications (Chan, 2018).

### **5.2.2 Expectations for ways of involvement**

The findings also revealed that the two participants had a clear desire to participate in the activities of the centre and expected more opportunities. According to Y's comments, she hoped that parental-involved activities such as the Christmas Party would be held on a more regular basis. This point is supported by research. Hiatt-Michael (2010) agrees that interaction between parents and teachers should be regular and continuous to create better collaborations. Second, regarding communication means, prior research backed up the desire for culturally responsive interaction channels. Although studies show that Chinese migrant parents are willing to fit into host-country cultures (Poureslami et al., 2013), participants in this project expressed strong expectations to be involved in one-on-one parent meetings or to receive written feedback from teachers. Given their limited English level, they had no choice but to engage with their children's learning through the commonly associated Chinese methods.

### **5.2.3 Barriers of parents' engagement**

According to the findings in this research, one of the first responses was invariably the difficulty of speaking English. Parents expressed the difficulties they had in grasping information in English and in improving their English level. If possible, they preferred to communicate in Mandarin. Unfortunately, as Hernandez (2004) points out, relying on the mother tongue seems to prevent efficient information exchange. In addition, when it comes to playing, skills are viewed as essential tools for free exploration in play in Chinese beliefs (Biggs, 2005). As a result, Chinese immigrant parents believe that their free play does not conflict with adult-led teaching (Wu, 2009), and they hoped for more structured instruction from teachers. Besides, with regard to the centre learning, the interviews revealed parents' dependence on the centre to guide children's learning. This is rooted in Asiatic cultures' hierarchy orientation, where parents tend to show a deeply embedded respect for authority and teachers, with multifaceted norms of conduct and language manners (Biggs, 2005). Because of the emphasis placed on academic endeavors, authority is profoundly assigned to schools and educators in Asian societies, and the interviews revealed an eagerly awaited definition of New Zealand home-centre relationships as highlighted by research (He, et al., 2011).

Last but not least, from the standpoint of home learning, the findings revealed that the two participants understood the benefits of play but were unaware of the dangers of over-ability early training on children's development. Each child's growth path is distinct. Involved in activities that are appropriate for their learning abilities, background knowledge, and present situation, children follow a natural road to their success (Carlsson-Paige et al., 2015). One of the rewards of learning in a fun and relaxing play is that speech-rich contexts aid in the development of children's concepts about signs, speech, and the written media, all of which are crucial parts of reading. In comparison, as a result of massive pressure to achieve above-ability expectations, there are long-term impacts on children's health and happiness (Carlsson-Paige et al., 2015). Parents may adjust their home learning plan accordingly if educators inform them about the rewards of play-based learning and the potential harm of over-age early training, resulting in an effective home-centre partnership. After all, compared with unofficial channel resources, the instruction given by educators is much more convincing for Chinese migrant parents.



## **Six Limitations, recommendations, and conclusion**

### **6.1 Limitations**

On reflection, four main limitations were found in this project. For starters, as small-scale qualitative research, the time and participants restrictions were unavoidable. Second, the experimental nature of the study and the following research design, simply recorded the perspectives and attitudes of the project participants. For these reasons, the data-driven narratives, the discussion and recommendations should be regarded as exploratory proposals. Chinese immigrants are diverse. So, I do not believe that this research provides a comprehensive picture of the aspirations of Chinese immigrant parents. Third, better results for this project could have been produced if multiple samples from various Chinese backgrounds had been taken into account. Fourth, the central of the project was preschool-age parents. It is possible that the aspirations of Chinese immigrant parents for school-aged children vary from the findings in this study. Overall, Chinese immigrant parents come from different walks of life. More research could be conducted to investigate the various types of families, their beliefs, and childrearing practices.

### **6.2 Recommendations**

Given the significance of parental involvement in ECE, as well as the findings that Chinese immigrant parents had clear involvement desires, fluid aspirations, and communication issues, the topic of what centres can do to enhance home-center collaborations arises. Based on new findings in the project, ECE teachers are expected to initiate ongoing and evident invitations and activities to understand, accept and support the aspirations of Chinese migrant parents. From the stand of participants, in the interviews, because of the participants' cross-city and cross-border life, although they were currently in Tauranga, they had evident educational aspirations for their children to keep up with the curriculum levels in Auckland and in China. To that end, they showed that they mainly used Chinese ways of teaching after school, in order to highlight cultural heritage. Teachers should understand that these expectations and childrearing practices are unavoidable for most cross-border immigrants who maintain family and community ties in their homelands. Under the influence of their dynamic experience in different places, their aspirations must be fluid and aimed at current goals. So, the importance of parent-teacher dialogues is highlighted by understanding and continuous partnership between families and centres. Also, from the perspectives of New Zealand ECE, some initiatives emphasize the importance of parental engagement in New Zealand's ECE programs. *Te Whāriki* (MoE, 2017), based on developmental and sociocultural theories, strongly encourage teachers to empower families to engage with their children's education. Again, *Our code, our standards* (Education Council, 2017) set it as a responsibility for teachers to support parent-

teacher partnerships. So, in the ECE programs, teachers are encouraged to initiate conversations or activities in an attempt to comprehend their cross-border childrearing practices and to implement responsive pedagogies (Poureslami et al., 2013).

In addition, more frequent and regular invitations of parental involvement are expected, like parent meetings, Christmas parties, mandarin weeks. Y: *“if those activities happened regularly, I would have more chances to know from teachers and other parents.... I can know better about the centre’s philosophy thus forming better ideas about my son’s learning in the centre...”* According to the findings of the study, ethnocultural parent meetings and written feedbacks help to reduce linguistic barriers in order to address the challenges of intercultural communication. According to Zhang's research in this literature review, the most significant barrier to Chinese immigrant parents' participation is lacking for a clear and obvious invitation. As a result, parent meetings and written feedback are ideal methods of inviting home-centre partnerships (Zhang et al., 2014). Furthermore, group meetings that reflect the collective psyche of Chinese cultures are likely to appeal to a large number of Chinese migrant parents (Zhang, 2016). Bilingual employees or translators can assist in bridging the language gap, but they should ideally be familiar with the educational setting (Zhang, 2016). Previous studies involving Chinese immigrant families show that these families expect their children grasp both Chinese and English (Wu 2009). Based on that hope, if parents see bilingual staff functioning in the parent meetings, it would be a promising signal for their children’s bilingual goals.

### **6.3 Conclusion**

This study made several contributions. Firstly, it confirmed the two Chinese immigrant parents’ top aspirations for children, personality and physical building, academic skills and social skills. Second, it identified the desire and fluid expectations as not static cross-city and cross-border parents in Tauranga. Third, it found barriers to their engagement, including the lack of proficiency in English and the multicultural context and the limited understanding of New Zealand -featured learning and home-centre partnership. Fourth, it discussed the social-cultural reasons behind the findings. Fifth, it provided potential recommendations for ECE teachers to boot the benefits of home-centre partnership with Chinese migrant parents. In conclusion, this study not only provided a better comprehension of the aspirations of the two Chinese immigrant parents of preschoolers in Tauranga, but it also offered findings that may instruct effective support that increases effectiveness of parental engagement, especially for Chinese immigrant parents of preschoolers in provisional cities.

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## Appendices

### Appendix A1 Participants Information Sheet (English)

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|                                      |
|--------------------------------------|
| <b>PARTICIPANT INFORMATION SHEET</b> |
|--------------------------------------|

Title of Project: *Understanding the educational aspirations of two preschool Chinese migrant parents in one ECE centre*

Dear XXX,

My name is Ying Guan and I am studying at Toi Ohomai Institute of Technology in a paper titled: Practitioner Research in Early Childhood Education settings. I am conducting a research project about the educational aspirations of preschool Chinese migrant parents.

I am seeking permission to research the preschool educational involvement of Chinese migrant parents. This research will involve face-to-face interviews for 30-45 minutes each time with you. Interviews may be repeated up to three times to gain a better understanding on the issues for you in Aotearoa New Zealand ECE. In the event of a lockdown, online video interviews meetings are preferred.

The data collected will be stored on my password protected personal computer for at least 3 years. I and my supervisor will have access to the consent forms (which he will keep in as locked filing cabinet). I will delete the information after the mandatory storage duration (at least 3 years).

All information and data provided will be treated as confidential. Names will not be used in the final report of the project. You will get to choose a pseudonym for yourself in the research. Participation is voluntary and you may withdraw any time up until the commencement of data analysis.

In addition, according to the “Statement of Rights”, you have the right to:

- Decline to participate;
- Decline to answer any particular question;
- Ask any questions about the study at any time during participation;
- Provide information on the understanding that your name will not be used unless you give permission to the researcher; you may choose a pseudonym
- To be given a copy of the research when it is concluded.

I hope the information you provide will contribute to a more accurate understanding of preschool Chinese migrant parents' aspirations and needs. Your information will potentially enable the centre to provide improved services to Chinese migrant children. You will receive a copy of the final project. Would you like this as a hard copy or PDF?

After the study, a report will be lodged with the Practice-Based Research course lecturers at Toi Ohomai Institute of Technology. Aspects of the report may also be used as a basis for papers presented at relevant conferences.

The Research Committee of Toi Ohomai Institute of Technology requires all participants to sign a consent form for any research conducted with human subjects. Please find attached a 'Consent to participate' form.

I am happy to discuss this research with you at any time. Please feel free to contact me if you have any questions regarding any part of this research.

I can be contacted at the following email address: [guanyinglsy@gmail.com](mailto:guanyinglsy@gmail.com)

My supervisor is Dr Richard Smith, and he can be contacted on: [richard.smith@toiohomai.ac.nz](mailto:richard.smith@toiohomai.ac.nz)

Thank you for your assistance.

Sincerely

Ying Guan

## Appendix A2 Participants Information Sheet (Mandarin)

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# TOI-OHOMAI

Institute of Technology

Title of Project: *Understanding the educational aspirations of two preschool Chinese migrant parents in one ECE centre*

### 参与者信息表

项目名称：理解在一家幼儿园中两位中国学龄前家长的教育期待和需求

亲爱的 xxx,

我叫关莹，我在 Toi Ohomai 理工学院学习，我正在进行一项关于幼儿教育领域的实践者研究，论文题目是：一家幼儿园里两位中国移民父母对学龄前儿童的教育期待。

这项研究将涉及面对面的访谈，为了充分了解你对孩子的教育需求和期待，每次访谈将持续 30-45 分钟，一共进行 3 次左右。如果由于疫情原因无法见面，首选在线视频会议。收集的数据将存储在我的密码保护的计算机上，并随时随请与您共享。我会在要求的存储期（至少 3 年）后删除信息。

提供的所有信息和数据都将被视为机密。参与是自愿的，参与者可以随时退出，直到数据分析开始。此外，根据“Statement of Rights”您有权：

拒绝参与；

拒绝回答任何特定的问题；

在参与过程中随时询问有关研究的任何问题；

除非您给予研究人员许可，否则您的姓名将不会被使用；

你可以选择一个假名。

当研究结束时，你会得到一份研究报告的副本。

我希望该项目提供的信息将有助于更准确地了解中国移民家长对学龄前儿童的愿望和需求，并有可能为更多的中国移民儿童提供更好的服务。

研究结束后，将向大井理工大学实践研究课程讲师提交一份报告。报告的各个方面也可以作为在有关会议上提交文件的基础。

Toi Ohomai 理工学院的研究伦理委员会要求所有参与者签署同意书，以进行任何与人类主题进行的研究。请找到附上的"同意参加"表格。

我很高兴随时与您讨论这项研究。

如果您对本研究的任何部分有任何疑问，请随时与我或我的导师 Richard Smith 博士联系。

我的邮箱：guanyinglsy@gmail.com

Richard Smith 博士的邮箱：richard.smith@toiohomai.ac.nz

感谢您的帮助。

真诚地

关莹

## Appendix B Participant Information Sheet for the centre manager

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# TOI-OHOMAI

Institute of Technology

Title of Project: *Understanding the educational aspirations of two preschool Chinese migrant parents in one ECE centre*

Dear (Centre manager),

My name is Ying Guan, a Master of Teacher Education student at Toi Ohomai Institute of Technology. Thank you for your kind support in my practicum. I am seeking your permission for me to undertake my graduation research in Little Sweethearts\*\*\*. It is a practitioner research project with the title “*Increasing preschool Chinese migrant parents' participation in their children's learning*”. The goal of this research is to identify the specific educational goals and aspirations of preschool Chinese migrant parents in the centre, as well as to develop responsive ways to enhance their engagement in children's learning.

Outside of the centre, two Chinese migrant parents will be interviewed for this study. There will be no photography or video linked to the centre, and all records will be through narrative writing.

In addition, according to the “Statement of Rights”, you have the right to:

- Decline to participate.
- Decline to answer any particular question.
- Withdraw from the study up to the time of data analysis.
- Ask any questions about the study at any time during participation.
- Provide information on the understanding that your name will not be used unless you give permission to the researcher; you may choose a pseudonym
- To be given a copy of the research when it is concluded.

All supplied data will be kept strictly private. Names will not be used in the project's final report. Participants will be invited to come up with their own pseudonyms. Participation is entirely optional, and they may withdraw at any moment prior to the start of data analysis. I believe that the project's findings will help to improve home-centre partnership.

After the study is completed, a report will be submitted to the Practice Based Research course instructors at Toi Ohomai Institute of Technology. Participants and the centre will both receive a copy of this report. Aspects of the report may also serve as the foundation for papers presented at relevant conferences.

Toi Ohomai Institute of Technology's Research Committee requires all participants to complete a permission form before participating in any research involving human beings. Please find attached the permission form for you.

I am always available to talk about this research with you. If you have any questions about any aspect of this research, please do not hesitate to contact me.

I can be reached through email: [guanyingsy@gmail.com](mailto:guanyingsy@gmail.com). Also, my supervisor Dr Richard Smith, can be contacted on [richard.smith@toiohomai.ac.nz](mailto:richard.smith@toiohomai.ac.nz)

Thank you for your assistance.

Sincerely

Ying Guan



### **Appendix C1 Interview questions (English)**

1. What are your top five educational aspirations for your child?
2. What are the existing initiatives in the centre to involve you in your child's centre-learning and home-learning?
3. How efficient are the initiatives of the centre?
4. If any, what are the barriers of your engaging in your child's centre-learning and home learning?
5. What do you think you and the centre can do to overcome the barriers and increase your involvement in your child's learning?

### **Appendix C2 Interview questions (Mandarin)**

1. 您对孩子 在幼儿园阶段 5 个最大学习目标是什么？
2. 幼儿园 现有 哪些举措 有利于 您 参与 到 孩子 在 幼儿园 和 在 家里 的 学习 中？
3. 这些 举措 的 效果 如何？
4. 这些 举措 的 障碍 是 什么 （如果 有的 话）？
5. 您 和 幼儿园 能 做 些 什么 来 克服 这些 障碍， 并 提高 您 在 孩子 学习 中 的 参与？

## Appendix D Approval letter



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Rotorua | Tauranga | Taupō | Tokoroa | Whakatāne

10 November 2021

*Ying Guan*

Dear Ying

Project title: *Understanding the educational aspirations of two preschool Chinese migrant parents in one ECE centre*

I am pleased to inform you that the above-mentioned project has been reviewed and approval has been granted by the Research Committee on 10.11.21. Thank you for completing the changes to this application that were required by the reviewers.

The approval number is TRC 2021.094. Please quote this approval number on any information provided to participants.

The project reference number is 21074. Please use this reference number when sending future correspondence to the Committee.

We wish you success in your research.

Yours sincerely

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read "Heather Hamerton".

**Dr Heather Hamerton**  
**Head of Research**

Cc: Richard Smith  
Project Supervisor